

Calculator Setup & 10 Traps

GCSE Maths Paper 3 (Calculator) · Wednesday 10 June 2026

Casio is the most common GCSE calculator (fx-83/85 GT and fx-991 ClassWiz). The keys below match those models — if yours differs, the menu names are the same. **Do this 60-second setup before you start the paper.**

60-Second Setup (do this first)

- **Reset to default:** **SHIFT** **9** **3** **=** **AC**. Clears any leftover STAT/TABLE mode from a previous user.
- **Check it says DEGREES:** look for a small **D** at the top of the screen. If you see **R** (radians) every trig answer will be wrong. Fix: **SHIFT** **MODE** → **3** (Deg).
- **Natural display on:** **SHIFT** **MODE** → **1** (MathIO) so fractions and surds show properly. Use **S↔D** to flip any answer to a decimal.

The 10 Marks-Losing Traps

- 1 **Radians instead of degrees.** The single most common Paper 3 error. No **D** on screen → every sin/cos/tan answer is wrong. **Fix: check for the D before question 1.**
- 2 **Squaring a negative.** The calculator does the power before the minus, so $-3^2 = -9$ but $(-3)^2 = 9$. Always wrap a negative in brackets before squaring.
- 3 **Rounding too early.** Round only the *final* answer. Keep the full value on screen and use **Ans** for the next step, or store it: **SHIFT** **STO** **A**. Early rounding loses the accuracy mark.
- 4 **Fractions over a sum.** Typing $1 \div 2 + x$ computes $(1 \div 2) + x$. For a fraction *over* a whole expression, bracket the bottom: $1 \div (2 + x)$.
- 5 **The quadratic / cosine-rule denominator.** In the cosine rule and quadratic formula, put the *whole* top and the *whole* bottom in brackets, e.g. $(-b + \sqrt{b^2 - 4ac}) \div (2a)$.

6 Standard form. Enter powers of ten with the **$\times 10^x$** (or **EXP**) button, *not* by typing $\times 10^\wedge$. Typing 3 **$\times 10^x$** 8 gives 3×10^8 .

7 Wrong answer format. If a question says "give your answer to 2 decimal places" or "as a percentage", a fraction or surd on screen scores 0. Press **S $\leftrightarrow$ D** to convert, then round as asked.

8 Inverse trig for angles. To find an angle use **SHIFT** then sin/cos/tan ($\sin^{-1}$). Forgetting SHIFT gives you a side ratio, not the angle.

9 Iteration without Ans. Type the formula once using **Ans** where x_n appears, press **=**, then keep pressing **=** — each press is the next iteration. Free marks if you know this.

10 Trusting the screen over the working. "Show that" and method-mark questions need every line written down. The calculator gives the answer; the examiner pays for the *working*. Write it out even when the number is obvious.

One topic still not clicking before Wednesday?

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